

Face-Rotation BFS Nets of the Six Regular Convex 4-Polytopes

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JCDG³ 2026

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0:20 (cumulative 0:20)

I am Takashi Yoshino, Toyo University. This talk is about nets of 4-dimensional polytopes: cutting one open so that the pieces do not overlap. I give one procedure that works for all six regular ones.

Unfolding a 4-polytope

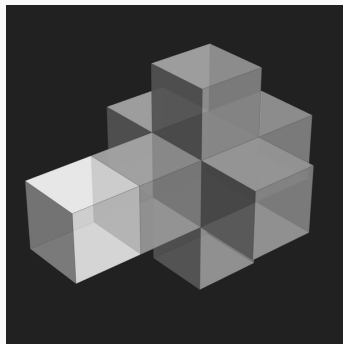
A **net** of a convex polytope: cut it open and lay the facets out flat, without overlap.

In 3D this is Dürer's problem, still open.

In 4D the facets are **3-dimensional cells** and the net lives in $\mathbb{R}^3$.

- Turney (1984): all 261 nets of the 8-cell
- Devadoss–Harvey (2023): *every* spanning tree works for the 5-, 8-, 16-cell — and some tree *fails* for the 600-cell

This talk: the 24-, 120- and 600-cell.



A net of the 8-cell: Dalí's cross

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Unfolding a 4-polytope

1:20 (cumulative 1:40)

Cut it open, lay it flat, no overlap. In 3D this is Dürer. In 4D the pieces are solids and the net can be printed.

The 8-cell is the tesseract and our net is Dalí's cross, one of Turney's 261 — forced, since the layers are 1 + 6 + 1 and all 6 trees give it.

Devadoss–Harvey settled the three small ones for *every* spanning tree, and showed the 600-cell has an overlapping one. End on the last line: those three are what this talk is about.

Click the picture; do not wait for it.

If the room wants the landscape: they also conjecture the 24- and 120-cell are not all-net. Not before slide 8 — earlier it sounds like a refutation, and it is not.



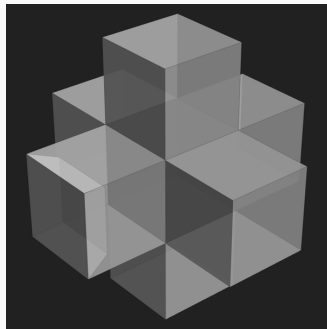
A net of the 8-cell: Dalí's cross

Face-rotation BFS

Fix a **root cell** r . Three steps.

- 1 Face-up.** Rotate in $SO(4)$ so the centroid of r sits on the $+w$ axis.
- 2 BFS.** Take a breadth-first spanning tree of the cell-adjacency graph from r . For each tree edge (parent p , child c), rotate c about the shared polygon until it lands in p 's hyperplane.
- 3 Project.** All cells now share one w -coordinate (spread $< 4 \times 10^{-13}$). Drop w .

The result is a net iff no two cells share interior volume.



Opening one BFS layer at a time, into Dalí's cross

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Face-Rotation BFS Nets of the Six Regular Convex 4-Polytopes

└ Face-rotation BFS

1:20 (cumulative 3:00)

The slowest slide. The rotation is forced: the shared polygon is the hinge. Step 3 is a check, not an assumption — the cells really do land in one hyperplane. Do not dwell on step 2; the next slide is about what it leaves open.

Click the picture and let it run while you read the three steps. It opens *by layer*: the six neighbours first, then a pause, then the last cell. On that pause, say that BFS fixes the layers.

If asked why the cells look bent: it is a 4D view, and it fades out as the net flattens. The last frame is the real net.

Face-rotation BFS

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Step 2 hides a choice

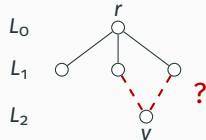
The layers are forced: L_d is the set of cells at distance d from r , and no rule can change that.

The **parent** is not. A cell in L_d may touch several cells of L_{d-1} , and BFS takes whichever one the implementation happens to reach first.

A geometric rule need not help

For the 5-, 8-, 16- and 24-cell the symmetries fixing r and v permute the candidates transitively, so **every** equivariant score — height along w , turning angle, the volume form — ties on all of them.

Ours breaks the tie by **cell index**, which is not equivariant either. **We come back to this.**



Two admissible parents
for v

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Face-Rotation BFS Nets of the Six Regular Convex 4-Polytopes

Step 2 hides a choice

0:50 (cumulative 3:50)

Short, but this is the slide the referees care about. Two beats. One: BFS fixes the layers, not the parents. Two: a cleverer geometric rule does not help. For those four the candidates are interchangeable under the symmetry group, so any equivariant score ties on all of them.

Checked on every cell with more than one candidate: 1, 11 and 7 cells for the 8-, 16- and 24-cell, each a single orbit. The 5-cell has none.

If pressed: it fails for the 120-cell, where 50 of the 71 such cells have candidates in two or more orbits. Do not volunteer this.

Close with “we come back to this”.

Step 2 hides a choice

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Two admissible parents
for v

The validity test, and a trap

A net is valid if for every pair of cells not joined by a tree edge,

$$\text{Vol}_3(\text{conv}(\mathbf{c}_i) \cap \text{conv}(\mathbf{c}_j)) \leq 10^{-8}.$$

Boundary contact is not overlap

Testing with closed-region membership instead counts a shared face, edge or vertex as an intersection. That is common for pointed cells, and it wrongly reports

16-cell 0/16, 24-cell 0/24, 600-cell 0/600.

Measuring *volume* ignores contact of measure zero.

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└ The validity test, and a trap

1:20 (cumulative 5:10)

Tell it as something that happened. The first run reported not a single valid net for these three — 0 of 16, 0 of 24, 0 of 600.

But cells that meet along an edge do not overlap. The fix is one line of code. Without it the theorem comes out backwards.

The validity test, and a trap

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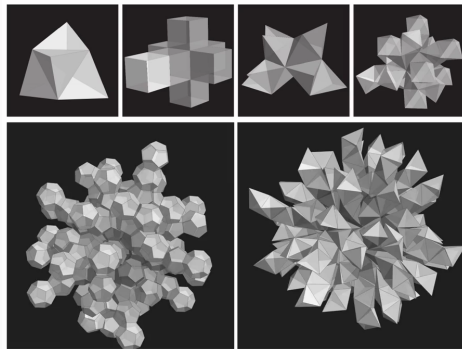
Main result

Theorem

For every regular convex 4-polytope and **every** root cell, the face-rotation BFS net is valid.

$5 + 8 + 16 + 24 + 120 + 600 = 773$ roots, one net each, all verified.

New beyond Devadoss–Harvey: **nets** for the 24-, 120- and 600-cell.



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└ Main result

1:40 (cumulative 6:50)

State the theorem, then let the picture sit. Six polytopes, one net each, all from root cell 1.

Say the number out loud: 773 roots, no exceptions. The overlap count is exactly zero every time — there are no near misses.

The three new ones are the ones Devadoss–Harvey had no nets for. Do not say “left open” — they settled the 600-cell, in the negative.

Click the figure and the two big nets turn, both at once. Eight seconds a turn. Let them run while you talk.

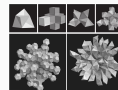
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Contrast: the apple-peel algorithm

A different family of spanning trees — a greedy spiral/zonal ordering (Yoshino–Chaidee, arXiv:2605.30373).

Polytope	BFS valid	apple-peel (RZ)	
		orderings	nets
120-cell	all roots	1440/1440	0/1440
600-cell	all roots	0/2400	—

The 120-cell has an ordering for every start and **never** a net; the 600-cell has no ordering at all.

Consequence

Having a valid *ordering* and having a valid *net* are independent properties.

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└─ Contrast: the apple-peel algorithm

1:30 (cumulative 8:20)

The companion algorithm peels the polytope like an apple, one cell at a time.

Read the two rows as opposite failures. The 120-cell always finds an order, and the order is never a net. The 600-cell never finds an order at all.

Then the block: ordering and net are independent. Do not explain how the apple-peel rule works. Only the contrast matters.

The arXiv number is there for anyone who wants the preprint; no need to read it out.

If asked what a valid ordering is: the peel visits every cell without dead-ending. Nothing to do with overlap — that is the next column.

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And more: the tie-breaking question

The abstract left this open:

“Whether validity extends to all BFS tie-breakings ... remains open.”

BFS layers do not depend on the rule, so a BFS tree is just a choice of parent, one layer up, for each cell. They can then be counted with no rule at all.

1,132,661 trees, no self-intersection. For the first four the rule is irrelevant. And BFS is not a vacuous restriction: the 600-cell (Devadoss–Harvey) and the 24-cell (Seamons 2026) are **not all-net**.

	trees / root	checked
5-cell	1	all
8-cell	6	all
16-cell	20,736	all
24-cell	32,768	all
120-cell	$\sim 1.8 \times 10^{44}$	20 random
600-cell	$\sim 1.8 \times 10^{65}$	20 random

Face-Rotation BFS Nets of the Six Regular Convex 4-Polytopes

└ And more: the tie-breaking question

1:50 (cumulative 10:10)

Quote the abstract first. This answers the question the abstract asked; it is not a side remark.

The idea: the layers depend only on distance from the root, so a BFS tree is one parent per cell from the layer above, and the family can be counted without naming a rule. Four exhausted, two sampled; if asked why only 20 per root, 10^{44} .

The last sentence is the payoff: it answers “why BFS and not every tree?”. Two of the six are not all-net, and BFS works on both. Say it as the reason, not an apology.

If asked: the 600-cell is their own Theorem 11; for the 24-cell, Seamons *confirms* their conjecture, in a 2026 preprint I checked myself.

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△ Warning: this does not extend

Beyond the regular case the rule stops being harmless.

Grand antiprism, 320 cells

rule A valid from **all 320** roots
rule B valid from **no** root

Same polytope, same roots, same family of BFS trees. Only the choice of parent differs.

Among the 64 convex uniform 4-polytopes this is not isolated: another swings from 1.8% to 99.8% of its roots.

What regularity buys is not that some tree works, but that the choice does not matter.



Grand antiprism, one valid net

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△ Warning: this does not extend

1:40 (cumulative 11:50)

This follows from the last slide, so say “and this is exactly what fails once you leave the regular case”.

The grand antiprism is the cleanest case: all 320 roots or none, decided by nothing but which parent you pick.

Then the closing sentence. Say it slowly; it is the line to remember.

If asked what A and B are: A is the textbook queue rule — max-index does the same here — and B is “take the smallest-indexed candidate parent”. The indices carry no geometry. B2 has the numbers.

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Grand antiprism, one valid net

- Why? A proof that does not enumerate.
- From BFS trees to **all** spanning trees: the 600-cell is not all-net (Devadoss–Harvey), nor is the 24-cell — Seamons (2026) confirms their conjecture. **Only the 120-cell is left.**
- For the 120- and 600-cell even the BFS family is open: 10^{44} and 10^{65} trees per root put enumeration out of reach, so an argument would have to be structural.
- What separates the uniform polytopes that are insensitive to the rule from those that are not?

Code, data and nets:

github.com/takashi-randomwalker/apple-peel-4d

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└ Open problems

0:40 (cumulative 12:30)

Do not read all four. Say the second and the last, point at the URL, and stop — “only the 120-cell is left” is the line worth saying. If pressed: producing nets can never refute that conjecture; one overlapping tree confirms it, refuting it needs all of them. The slot ends at 16:57, leaving about two minutes for questions.

Backups: B1 reachable trees, B2 the three rules, B3 the runcinated 24-cell, B4 what does *not* separate them, B5 the data of the six.

If the open problems start drawing questions you would rather not field, slide 6 is one press back — the nets are moving there.

Open problems

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Backup: “BFS tree” is bigger than what BFS returns

A traversal reaches a tree iff its parent choices admit a total order, i.e. iff the constraint digraph $p(v) \rightarrow q$ is acyclic.

	BFS trees	reachable	
8-cell	6	6	100%
16-cell	20,736	4,896	23.6%
24-cell	32,768	2,592	7.9%

So of the 786,432 trees verified for the 24-cell, only 62,208 are reachable by any traversal. The obstruction is a *cycle* in the constraints, not merely two cells sharing two candidate parents: the 16-cell has no such pair and still leaves three quarters of its trees unreachable.

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Backup: which rules were compared

	queue	max-index	min-index
Runcinated 24-cell	0/240	0/240	0/240
Runcitruncated 600-cell	47/2640	2635/2640	2627/2640
Runcitruncated 120-cell	2570/2640	2640/2640	2151/2640
Grand antiprism	320/320	320/320	0/320

“queue” is the textbook BFS loop, neighbours scanned in index order.
“min/max-index” choose, for each cell, the smallest or largest indexed candidate parent.

Uniformly random trees are harsher still: of the 61 uniform polytopes valid from every root under the queue rule, 13 fail within 10 random trees, the grand antiprism among them — and every one of the four polytopes with 2,640 cells fails all ten, whether or not it is one of the 61.

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Backup: the one that no rule could unfold

Runcinated 24-cell $t_{0,3}\{3, 4, 3\}$, 240 cells, 0/240 under all three index rules. Ask instead for a *symmetric tree*: a BFS tree invariant under $H \leq \text{Stab}(r)$ exists iff every cell has a candidate parent fixed by its stabilizer in H . Here $|\text{Aut}| = 2,304$, with two cell orbits, and the largest such H has order 3.

root orbit	$ \text{Stab}(r) $	$\max H $	H -invariant	random
48 (octahedra)	48	3	70/600	0/600
192 (triangular prisms)	12	3	83/600	0/600

The control is the point: unconstrained trees at those roots give nothing. Transitivity on each orbit then gives a valid net from **all 240 roots** — not a polytope without a net, but one whose nets no index rule finds.

(No conflict with slide 4: there the candidates form one orbit under the *full* stabilizer, so no invariant tree exists at all.)

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(No conflict with slide 4: there the candidates form one orbit under the full stabilizer, so no invariant tree exists at all.)

Backup: what does *not* separate them

Cell degree fails both ways. The grand antiprism and the snub 24-cell have cells of degree 4 — the poverty that stops apple-peel on the 600-cell — yet are valid from every root, while the runcinated 24-cell has minimum degree 5 and is valid from none. Nor does high degree help: every prism has a cell of degree up to 92 and all 17 are fine, and the root-dependent runcitruncated 120-cell carries cells of degree 32.

Angular defect at an edge — 2π less the dihedral angles meeting there, zero exactly when those cells tile $\mathbb{R}^3$ around it. For the regular six it is one number, and it orders them *exactly* by how hard they proved to be: 148.4° , 90° , 77.9° , 31.6° , 10.3° , 7.4° . Among the uniform ones it breaks both ways: the omnitruncated 120-cell shares its minimum defect, 0.736° , with the root-dependent runcitruncated 120-cell and is valid from every root, while the runcinated 24-cell sits at 10.5° , above many that are. Weighting by depth or by size does not repair it.

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Backup: the six polytopes

Polytope	Symbol	V	F	C	Cell	deg	depth	trees / root
5-cell	$\{3, 3, 3\}$	5	10	5	tetrahedron	4	1	1
8-cell	$\{4, 3, 3\}$	16	24	8	cube	6	2	6
16-cell	$\{3, 3, 4\}$	8	32	16	tetrahedron	4	4	20,736
24-cell	$\{3, 4, 3\}$	24	96	24	octahedron	8	3	32,768
120-cell	$\{5, 3, 3\}$	600	720	120	dodecahedron	12	5	1.8×10^{44}
600-cell	$\{3, 3, 5\}$	120	1200	600	tetrahedron	4	15	1.8×10^{65}

deg counts the cells sharing a 2-face; *depth* is the eccentricity of the cell-adjacency graph, the same from every cell. The layers are 1+4; 1+6+1; 1+4+6+4+1; 1+8+14+1; 1+12+32+42+32+1; and sixteen layers for the 600-cell.

The 24-cell row tells the two families apart: every BFS tree of it fits in $1+8+14+1$, whereas the overlapping spanning tree of Seamons puts 13 of its 24 cells deeper than their distance from the root.

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Polytope	Symbol	V	F	C	Celli	deg	depth	roots / root
5-cell	(3,3,3)	5	10	5	tetrahedron	4	1	1
8-cell	(4,3,3)	16	24	8	cube	6	2	6
10-cell	(3,3,4)	8	32	15	tetrahedron	4	4	20/25
120-cell	(3,4,5)	24	96	24	octahedron	6	5	30/50
240-cell	(3,5,6)	600	720	120	dodecahedron	12	5	1.8×10^{14}
800-cell	(3,3,5)	1200	1200	600	tetrahedron	4	5	1.8×10^{19}

deg counts the cells sharing a σ -face; depth is the eccentricity of the cell-adjacency graph, the same from every cell. The layers are 14c2: 14651; 1464+6441; 148+8411; 151+242+422+224 and sixteen layers for the 600-cell.

The 242-cell root tells the two families apart: every BFS tree of it fits in 148+841+1, whereas the overlapping spanning tree of Seamon's puts 13 of its 242 cells deeper than their distance from the root.